Point of View

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Explicit

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

Characters:
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by SolarPoweredFlashlight

Summary

Adora and She-Ra are split by magic shenanigans, and Catra says "now kiss".

Notes

This fic was written as part of the 2021 She-Ra Anniversary Big Bang! I was enormously fortunate to have Vee as my partner, and she did all the art contained within the fic. Check out her fabulous, sexy artwork on her twitter!

"You said to call you if we needed extra muscle," Entrapta says over the comm.

Only her legs are visible, and the rest of her is lost inside one of her giant robots, doing repairs, and the peppy tone of her voice doesn't match the dramatic damage that seems to have been done to her squadron of cleanup bots. "So far Beast Island hasn't offered any real challenges that Hordak and I couldn't overcome on our own, but this particular artifact seems to require magical intervention. I'm sure I could invent something with enough time, but it seems significantly more efficient just to utilize She-Ra."

Beside Adora, Catra's ears give away her dislike of that phrasing. Adora touches her arm lightly to try to soothe her bristling - she knows Entrapta doesn't mean any harm by it.

"We can be there in a couple hours," Adora says. "I'll see if Bow and Glimmer are available to come too. We don't know what this artifact is exactly but it's obviously capable of defending itself."

"Oh, *very* capable," Entrapta says enthusiastically. "Once you disable it I'm going to be pulling it apart to find out how it works. I can already think of several applications for its unique energy field."

"Please just be *careful,"* Adora sighs, resigned to the fact that Entrapta will gleefully play with dangerous tech if she feels there's something to be learned from it. She already has a suspicion they'll be fighting this 'artifact' more than once.

"So, here it is!" Entrapta announces.

"It's just a big pink ball of light," Catra says, nonplussed.

It is, indeed, just a big pink ball of light.

"Watch this," Entrapta says, with an excited little squeal. She picks up a rock off the ground and throws it at the humming pink energy field - it goes through with no problem. "Organic matter, no issue. Now watch *this."* She fishes a bolt out of one of her many pockets, and lobs the greasy bit of hardware in the same direction as the rock. It hits the pink wall, freezes in place, makes a horrible *SNAP* noise, and then launches back in their direction. Catra shrieks and ducks as it nearly whings her between the eyes.

"Huh," Bow says, watching carefully. He'd insisted on coming along, even though he isn't magical, just as backup - Adora was relieved, honestly, since he's usually the best at translating Entrapta's technical jargon when she gets excited about something and starts rambling. "So it defends itself from technology, but not from organic material. How does magic play into all this?"

"I ran *several* experiments before I decided to ask for help," Entrapta says. "I'm able to pass through the field, but any pieces of technology I take with me are destroyed and then repelled the same as that bolt was. It seems to me a field with that level of sophistication and output potential must have some kind of incredible power source, so I did some digging and I realized it was being powered by *magic* - specifically, the ambient magic of the planet that was released when the failsafe deactivated the Heart. If I could get access to the First Ones tech at the heart of the energy field, I could hack into it and interrupt its ability to draw power from the planet's magic, but I can't bring any technology through the defensive field, not even the basic interfacing wiring I'd need. So if it uses magic to power itself, I thought maybe we could try *overloading* it by putting too much power into its system and shutting down the field that way. Since your magic is inherent, it means you're all organic and should be able to get through the field and get close enough to blast it with magic!"

"Oh, okay!" Adora says, grinning. Nice and simple then - turn into She-Ra, smash some evil thing with her sword. Easy enough.

"Wait," Catra says, "What does this thing even *do,* besides protect itself? Like, what was it built for? It's First Ones tech, right? But if it ended up on Beast Island, that means it's dangerous in some way, or they didn't trust it, or it didn't work right."

"Oh, absolutely!" Entrapta says, hopping from foot to foot. "This is a dumping ground for old tech that did something a little too well or not quite the way they wanted it to. Every single piece of

recovered technology is a puzzle within a puzzle within a *lot* of fascinating data."

"That doesn't answer my question," Catra says. She might seem annoyed with Entrapta if it weren't for the little indulgent smile tugging at the corner of her mouth.

"Oh, I have *no idea* what the artifact at the center of the field actually does! That's why I'm so excited to get to look at it once you guys are done!"

"I'm sure whatever it is, all it'll take is a couple whacks with the sword to make it *stop* doing whatever it does," Adora says, grinning at Catra. She's pretty confident she can handle this.

"Honestly, I could probably take this thing out on my own," Glimmer says. "We might not even need She-Ra, since I can teleport past the field entirely."

"I don't know, you guys, I have a weird feeling about this thing," Catra mutters.

"It'll be *fine,"* Adora says confidently. She takes Glimmer's hand. "C'mon, let's go smash this thing and get home to Bright Moon in time for dinner."

“Now you’re talking!” Glimmer says, with a bloodthirsty smirk. Adora feels the familiar tingle of Glimmer’s magic race up her arm, and then the world winks away and comes back into view again. They’ve bypassed the outer edge of the defensive field entirely, but - Catra’s right. There’s something *weird* about this. All the hair on Adora’s arms and the back of her neck prickles nervously.

“Is that it?” Adora asks, pointing at a lopsided spire overgrown with moss and blinking a sequence of rapid lights.

“Looks like,” Glimmer says. “I’m gonna just hit it with some magic from here and see what happens before we get any closer.” She holds out her hand to charge magic into it -

Glimmer suddenly shudders and gasps, a glow surrounding her and then dispersing. Tiny twinkling motes of purple light burst outward from Glimmer’s body, scattering through the air and tumbling, growing, expanding into swirling, sparkling -

“Portals?” Adora mutters, looking at them. There have to be a dozen of the sparkly purple discs surrounding them now, and she tenses, waiting from something to come out of them, but… nothing does. Oh, shit, and - “Glimmer, are you okay??” Adora’s head whips around; Glimmer is frowning, staring at her hands.

“I can’t use my magic,” Glimmer whispers. “It’s like - it’s like being in space. The magic isn’t in me. Or it’s - “ she glowers and grunts, concentrating, and another burst of light splits off of her and forms a swirling puddle of magic. “It’s like I can’t keep it inside my body?”

“Weird,” Adora mutters, approaching one of the pools of Glimmer’s magic. She summons her sword to her hand, and that works fine. “It doesn’t seem to be affecting me, at least?” Tentatively, experimentally, she pokes the end of her sword into one of the purple portals.

“Careful!” Glimmer yells, and Adora glances back over her shoulder to see the tip of her blade has emerged from another one of the portals, narrowly avoiding jabbing Glimmer in the eye.

“Oops!!” Adora quickly pulls the sword back out and watches the tip retreat back out of the other portal. “This is *so* weird, Glimmer.”

“I know,” Glimmer says, frowning. “It feels… icky, somehow. But it isn’t impacting you, right? Hurry up and destroy that thing, I really don’t like this.”

Nodding in agreement, Adora raises her sword above her head.

“Adora,” Catra’s voice calls from the other side of the energy field, “Adora, wait - !”

But it’s too late.

“For the Honor of Grayskull!”

And then Adora feels it.

A weird, tingling, pulling, tugging feeling.

This isn’t what her transformation is supposed to feel like.

Something *yanks* at the magic inside of her, and it comes tumbling loose in a great golden glow. The ball of light grows, and unfolds, and stands, and -

And materializes into She-Ra.

Adora looks down at herself. She is still very much Adora.

She looks up at She-Ra.

And She-Ra looks back at her in surprise.

I look back at myself, and all I can think is -

"Oh, *shit,"* I say - but not *me.* The me I'm looking at who isn't me.

I glance down at myself and - yeah, okay - okay, so -

So I'm She-Ra.

I'm She-Ra, and that's Adora. That's me. That's -

"Adora," Glimmer says, looking in shock between the two of us, "Did you - is - why are there *two* of you??"

"I don't kn - "

"I don't know," we both say at the same time, and then lock eyes uncomfortably.

“Fascinating!!” Entrapta shouts from the other side of the glowing barrier. “The device clearly has some kind of siphoning effect on corporeal magic that *separates* it from the user!!”

I feel dizzy.

And then -

And then I see it in myself - in *Adora.*

It’s bizarre.

I’ve never watched it from the outside before - that flash of honest vulnerability followed immediately by the determination to hide any fear or discomfort.

Damn. I’m not a very good liar, am I? I - Adora? - don’t look half as confident as I probably think I do.

And now she’s looking at *me,* that Adora, seeing - seeing the same thing in my face?

But I’m not just Adora.

I'm *She-Ra.*

She-Ra is supposed to be reassuring. In charge. Confident. Capable.

"Let's go smash that thing," I say, definitively.

And just like that, relief flashes in my - in Adora's - eyes.

I always knew I kind of depended on She-Ra, but… wow. It's something else to actually watch it in my own expression.

"Right," Adora says, and Glimmer doesn't say anything, just keeps looking at the pair of us in astonishment.

I watch Adora take a quick glance back at Catra.

She thinks she's being subtle - I know because in her place, I'd think I was being subtle too - but she really isn't, and it's obvious she's bolstering herself with the sight of the one person we've always been able to count on.

I look back too.

She-Ra needs Catra just as much as Adora always has.

Catra rubs her face in theatrical, agonized frustration and grumbles something about weird magic bullshit, but when she pulls her hands away and sees both of us looking, she turns sheepish.



Artwork by @DMSR__

How obvious is it that I'm completely freaking out on the inside right now?

(I steal another glance at my other self and… wow, yeah, so, probably pretty obvious. Adora looks like she's about to buzz out

of her skin with how overwhelmed she is.)

"Hey, you've got this," Catra says firmly. "Go swing that giant sword of yours and do a little casual property damage. Easy peasy, you've done it a million times."

I nod, suppressing a small smile at the playful jab, and watch Adora do the same.

We find the piece of ancient machinery, clicking and whirring and pulsing and blinking all sorts of lights in a pattern I'm sure Entrapta would be happy to sit and interpret. My job is just to make it stop doing… whatever it's doing. Blinking lights and all.

I hoist the sword above my head and then… I hesitate.

"What's wrong?" Adora asks, instantly aware of my reluctant body language.

"I just - if this makes me disappear, or like, go back into you, or something, I - " I feel my confidence start to waver as I give voice to the words, and I feel control slipping from my grasp. I know my She-Ra form doesn't stick around long if I let doubt creep in and take over. What would happen if I lost my hold on the ancient magic of She-Ra before getting rid of this Eternian junk tech? Would I become a second regular Adora? Would I just… vanish?

Is that what I'm about to do to myself by smashing the device?

No.

I'm being selfish.

If I'm just some magical extension of Adora's mind being used to operate the separate She-Ra body, then I'm not vanishing so much as going back to where I'm supposed to be.

And if I'm… my own unique me, a She-Ra that isn't Adora, that isn't anybody *but* She-Ra, then I should fix that as soon as possible, because it wouldn't be right for me to deny Adora the power to transform by staying separate.

"Wait," Adora says, brows furrowing, eyes fixed hard on me. She seems to have figured out what I'm thinking - which, well, makes sense because I guess we're the same person - and reaches for me. "Maybe we should get Entrapta to run some tests or something before we wreck it. What if - what if we don't understand what it'll do to you, after it's gone?"

But we know each other.

I know myself.

I turn my back to her and lift the sword again.

"This is what I'm here for," I say, quietly. "You know that."

I swing.

In a way, it would have been more convenient if I had just disappeared when I disabled the device.

I don't like having to see the strained tension in my own - in *Adora's* face.

"Catra won't like that," she says, softly enough that Glimmer won't hear it.

It's eerie that I'd just been thinking that exact same thing.

"She won't," I agree.

I imagine we both share the brief, fleeting impulse to just keep it a secret from her, to hide the fact that I slipped back into my (our?) old bad habit of always following the route of self-sacrifice.

Entrapta saves us from much more talking or thinking about it by rushing over and flitting back and forth between her fascination with the machine and her fascination with its lingering effects. Glimmer's sparkly short-range portals are still hanging around too, so at least it isn't just *me,* but still…

"Oh, this is the *perfect* opportunity to show you my new *laboratory!"* Entrapta croons, and I allow myself to be herded back to Darla so that we can head there for some tests and hopefully some answers about just how permanent this split is.

I stand apart from the group and watch awkwardly; I don't belong in Adora's chair. I'm not Adora, am I? I'm She-Ra. That other me is the real Adora.

I shouldn't be surprised when Catra comes and finds me in my corner.

I shouldn't be, but I am.

"Hey," she says, so, so softly.

There was a time when I never thought she'd be capable of that kind of open softness in my presence when I was wearing this form.

"Hey," I say, trying for confident and aloof.

She raises an eyebrow.

Even seven feet tall and glistening with magic, I guess she still sees right through me.

"You okay?"

"Yeah, of course," I say, trying again.

(Lying again.)

"Adora," she admonishes.

"I'm not Adora," I correct quickly. "I'm She-Ra. *That's* Adora." I jerk my chin at the real me sitting in my chair.

“You’re an idiot, is what you are,” Catra murmurs, slipping her hand into mine. Her fingers always feel so small and dainty against me when I’m in this shape. “I don’t know how many times I’ve told you that She-Ra *is* you.”

“This is different,” I say, unable to look her in the eye. “This is complicated.”

“It’s not complicated. You’re both Adora.”

I can’t bring myself to respond to her touch, to wrap my fingers around her hand in reciprocation. Not while the real Adora is right here. It feels… wrong. It feels like I’m not allowed.

“It doesn’t matter. Entrapta will figure out a way to fix this,” I say, feigning confidence, straightening my shoulders. I see Adora glance back over her shoulder, watching us.

“The scans are showing a slow dissemination of the strange formation of magic at the molecular level that caused it to

separate from its caster in an atypical fashion," Entrapta says, after an hour of poking and prodding me.

I'm pretty sure some of them are for her own personal edification more than anything to do with the actual current situation - she's been angling for the chance to 'study' She-Ra for years now, and now she's got all the saliva samples and strands of hair and test tubes filled with magical essence that she could ever want.

(At least, I hope she doesn't want more than this. What would she even *do* with it all? No. I decide I don't want to know.)

"So that means…?" Catra says, from where she's put herself - consciously? subconsciously? - between Adora and I.

"It's already starting to undo itself now that you're away from the effects of the magical disruption field, basically," Entrapta clarifies. "I wonder if Mermista's magic forms those patterns naturally - I wonder if you could *reverse engineer* the effect of that machine and do the opposite - if we made Mermista's magic tied to her physical form like yours is, would she *spray water* from her *body?"*

"Uh, Entrapta," Bow says, with a grimace, "Remember that conversation we had about making sure you have explicit, informed consent before you experiment on somebody?"

"Oh, of course! I'll *ask* her before I go messing around with the molecular structure of her biologically inherited magic. I doubt she'd hold still long enough otherwise!" Entrapta barks a sudden peal of laughter that is fundamentally unsettling.

I notice Catra gives a fond little smile, even as everybody else frets about the chaos we may have to deal with down the line on the heels of this addition to Entrapta's technical menagerie.

"So," Adora says, and I observe with strange fascination the way a line has appeared between her eyebrows - my eyebrows. I know she isn't making that face consciously. "It's going to go away on its own? Does that mean She-Ra will just… vanish?"

"Be reabsorbed, is probably more accurate," Entrapta says. "And yes, it's already happening! I'd give it approximately eighteen hours."

"Eighteen hours," Adora parrots, still wearing that concerned, thoughtful expression. "So what do we do until then? Just wait?"

"I would like to propose we go *home,"* Glimmer says.

(Glimmer hates Beast Island; I can't really say I blame her. It still gives me the heebie jeebies.)

"Back to Bright Moon, then," I suggest, and Adora seems to jump in surprise at the sound of my voice, like she'd managed to forget that I'm here.

"Y-yeah," Adora says, with a weird smile plastered on her face. "Back to Bright Moon."

"Does it count as two votes if you're literally agreeing with yourself?" Bow chuckles glibly, as we make our way back to the ship.

Nobody else seems to notice how completely, *utterly* freaked out Adora is.

(How freaked out *I* am.)

Nobody, of course, but Catra.

We make it back in time for dinner, and then Bow and Glimmer say goodnight.

I hang back, watching, as Catra walks away with that person who is me and isn't me all at once.

I'm still standing there in the hallways as they reach the door to my bedroom.

But is it mine?

Is any of this mine?

It's an oddly familiar sensation. When I first came to Bright Moon, it definitely felt like none of this was mine. It all belonged to She-Ra, not to me. Not to Adora.

But now… now I'm She-Ra - *just* She-Ra - and Adora is there in her rightful place, getting to be a person instead of a symbol, instead of a glowing, magical manifestation. This all belongs to Adora now, not to She-Ra.

And she looks… comfortable. She looks happy. She looks like she belongs here.

Is that how I look? Is that how I feel?

Like Bright Moon is home. Like this is where I belong -

No. Not where I belong so much as where I've chosen to be.

Catra turns back towards me, an ear flicking. Adora follows her gaze, and they both regard me, puzzled.

"Are you coming?" Catra asks.

"Me?" I gawk, suddenly sheepish. "No, uh, no I don't - I wouldn't - I wouldn't want to intrude, you know, I don't really know like, where I would sleep, or anything, and - it's fine, you know, I'll just - I'll just take a walk around the gardens until I - uh - you know - like, evaporate or something, I guess?"

Adora stares at me in astonishment, then leans in and whispers something to Catra.

Catra's mouth twitches, like she's trying not to laugh.

"Adora," she says with a sigh, and she's looking at *me,* not at the me that's actually Adora, "You're being an idiot. Come here and come to bed."

It's not like I can honestly say I'm tired - it's been a weird day, but not a physically strenuous one. But, well.

Catra's always been my greatest weakness. I've never been much good at resisting her, even when I'm seven feet tall and wearing a tiara.

I follow shyly after them, and, as I duck into the familiar room, try to fight the sense that I don't belong there, the feeling that I'm an intruder.

And then the door closes, and Catra presses hard against me, reaching up to grab my face and pull me down so that she can kiss me.

Instantly the tension melts out of my body. Everything goes away except for Catra, Catra, Catra, and it feels so immediate and so freeing and so - so *simple.*

But then my eyes flutter open and there, over Catra's shoulder, is *Adora* watching.

I pull away, sudden apologies spilling from my lips.

"Hey," Catra whispers, interrupting me, looking worried, "Take it easy. You're not doing anything wrong."

My eyes flick to Adora.

“I - I don’t know if this is okay,” I say to my other self. She frowns at me - confused, I think.

“I don’t know why it wouldn’t be,” she says.

“That’s not the same as you saying you’re okay with it,” I retort, hearing a certain tone that I recognize from the many, many times I’ve hedged an awkward conversation in this exact way.

“I mean - why should I get the final say? You’re - you’re *me,* right? There’s no reason to be bothered by it. I guess it’s just… really weird to see from the outside. It’s not the same as… y’know, watching in a mirror.”

I remember, very suddenly, a very special occasion involving me and Catra and a mirror strategically positioned at the end of our bed. The memory puts a little smirk on my face and heat in my cheeks and I wonder if -

Yeah. Yeah, the other me is smirking too. I think we’re thinking of the same thing.

“That was a fun night,” I venture. Adora huffs a sudden laugh, and -

Huh. I'm cute when I laugh, when the tension breaks and suddenly my mask slips a little unexpectedly. There's a softness, a tiredness there that I never expected would be… kind of charming.

It's strange, but I feel a warm fondness blossoming in my chest, fondness for myself, for *Adora,* as if she's an old friend and not literally *me.*

"Adora," Catra says, drawing two sets of eyes to herself, "Come to bed." She reaches out and touches my wrist, flashes a smile up at me, then takes my hand and walks me over to where Adora is, takes *her* hand too, and guides us both to the bed.

"Uh," Adora mumbles, allowing herself to be meekly led, "Like - like usual?"

And I already know what she's thinking, what she means by that.

She's asking if Catra expects us to get naked, because that's, well - that's how we usually sleep.

Catra raises an eyebrow at her, then releases both our hands and pointedly pulls her shirt up and over her head.

Embarrassed, I avert my gaze out of a desire to be respectful, to not intrude, to not overstep and make things weird -

"Adora," Catra sighs, and then when I don't respond to that, she gets right up into my personal space, reaches up to take my chin in one hand - fuck, I love the feeling of her hands on my face - and turns me back to look at her. "You do understand that just because you're currently split into two bodies doesn't mean one of you is in a relationship with me and one of you isn't, right?"

"Are you sure?" I whisper.

"You're my partner," Catra says, and the word fills me with a tingling thrill as potent as any magic I've ever felt. "Sometimes my partner is tall and glowy and has a stupid cape. Sometimes she's not tall and glowy and has an ugly jacket instead."

"It's *functional,"* Adora mutters defensively, as I think that exact thing. My poor jacket. What did it ever do to Catra?

"And *sometimes,* apparently," Catra continues, as if she didn't hear this protest, holding my chin very firmly in her hand, "My partner is both of those things at the same time. Got it?"

I breathe in, slow and steady, and then I nod.

"Good. Now kiss me, you big dummy."

I still flick my eyes once, uncertainly, at Adora.

She gives the tiniest of nods.

It feels weird still, but, well -

I love Catra. I love her so much the idea of not being allowed to kiss her and hold her frankly aches more than the looming thought that in about fifteen hours I'm going to vanish into magic dust.

I lean down and wrap her in my arms and kiss her, and as I do I feel her relax and soften into it. She's never been fragile, my Catra, but she feels so precious and finely-wrought when I'm so much bigger than her, like the neck of a violin, meant to be held carefully and touched meaningfully.

I realize, as she kisses back and exhales with the softest of shudders, that my reluctance has been upsetting her.

Selfish. *Selfish,* to be so inside my own head that I didn't realize my insecurity and uncertainty was hurting the person I care about most in the world.

She pulls away and she looks… happier. Relaxed?

And then she turns to face Adora.

"Now you," Catra says, imperious but fond.

The master of my heart, the voice I can never ignore.

I watch it all cross my own face. I can see, actually *see* how much I love her.

Adora closes the distance and takes Catra's cheek in one hand and -

Hah. And then she sends *me* the little glance, the uncertain question.

And I suppose this is how she felt, a moment ago - this revelation that no, of course it doesn't bother me.

I give her my own nod of approval.

Her eyes turn back to Catra and then she pulls their faces together.

And you know, she's right.

It's incredible and strange to watch from the outside, to see the way dim blue crystal light dances down my neck as my jaw works ever so gently, the way shadow plays between my knuckles as I brush my thumb across Catra's face, a caress that speaks to how urgently I always want to be touching her, want to be reassuring her, even while we're kissing.

And *Catra* -

To watch from the outside as Catra and I kiss, to see her from behind and watch the rise and fall of her breathing, the soft motions of her shoulder blades, to allow the perfect curve of her hips to draw my eyes as she rocks them so, so slightly into the steadily heating kiss -

I find myself forgetting how strange this all is, because… well.

This kind of view of Catra is nothing short of a gift from the universe.

It *does* make me wish I were touching her, but -

But I don't know if that's allowed, if it would be weird and uncomfortable for Adora if I were to join in unprompted.

I'm trying to figure out how to ask about what the boundaries are in this extremely unusual situation when I hear a surprised, needy little sound that it takes me a second to realize came from *Adora.*

(Do I *really* sound like that? I - is it weird that it kind of excited me when I didn't know who made it?)

There's a sound of fabric hitting the floor, and I realize the noise was in response to Catra slipping her hands up under that aforementioned jacket and pushing it deftly off of Adora's shoulders.

Catra is -

Catra is undressing me while I watch.

Or, well. Undressing *Adora?*

I see Catra's ear tilt back towards me, catch the smug edge of a smirk tugging at her lips, and I know all too well that it means she can hear my heartbeat.

"Don't think I've forgotten about you," Catra murmurs, and I feel my pulse *leap.*

Fuck, I love her.

Both of them turn to look at me, a sort of foggy, dazed, hungry expression starting to creep over their faces. An answering flush of heat spreads through me at the realization that Catra is wearing the *look* - the one that means she has ambitions of more than just kissing tonight.

I glance at Adora, watch as her eyebrows furrow and then jolt up.

She swallows and blushes and looks at me - looks *up* at me -

And something in me *responds* to the sight.

It's not really like looking at yourself in a mirror at all. You can inspect without being seen, and the person you're looking at moves without knowing what's being perceived, or how it looks to the other person, and -

And I wonder what she sees when *she* looks at *me,* because *I* see someone tired, and vulnerable, and scared, and for maybe the first time ever it doesn't make me filled with frustration or self-loathing or impatience with my own flaws.

It makes me want to reach out and hold her, to protect her, to give her somewhere to rest.

Fuck. Is that really how other people see me?

And now, now I see those familiar eyes of mine tracing my body, questioning, indulging in a flicker of open curiosity.

That's the other thing about a reflection in a mirror - it looks back when you look. Those eyes don't ever flick down, half lidded, exploring as you keep your own eyes on the tiniest crickles at the edges of the eyes, at the smallest press and lift of thoughtful brows.

I swallow, because suddenly I'm not sure what that other me is thinking.

I stand almost at attention, feeling absurdly bashful.

"What?" I finally ask, when I can't take it anymore.

"I - sorry," Adora says quickly, and she looks back up at me, and - wow, okay, she's *blushing.* "I've never gotten to - to really *look* at myself when I'm She-Ra."

I feel a strong impulse to flex melodramatically and flash a grin and ask if she likes what she sees, but the situation is *just* a little too weird to be able to pull it off unselfconsciously, I think. So instead, I ask another question:

"What's it like? Seeing - " I almost say seeing *Her.* I guess I'm really in no position to talk like She-Ra isn't me, since I am objectively She-Ra in this strange, strange circumstance. "Seeing it from the outside?"

"I feel like," Adora murmurs, brows pinching thoughtfully, "Like we weren't always so - uh - so muscular? And also did we get even taller?"

Something about the way she says that feels *right.* I like being a *we* instead of a *you and I.*

"You're not imagining it," Catra says, and I wonder just what *she's* been seeing, as Adora and I stand here ogling each other. "You got taller after Prime's ship." Catra grins, saunters over to me. She does a little spin and walks backwards the rest of the way, pressing her back against my front so suddenly that I exhale a surprised little huff and reflexively wrap an arm around her waist.

I feel the soft rumble of her purr start up against me.

"See?" Catra says, nestled into my hold. "I used to come up to your chin when you were She-Ra. Ever since you came back for

me, since you got this new form - " She demonstrates the difference in height by holding her hand sideways between the top of her head and the underside of my chin. Huh. So like a full four inches or so taller?

"I always kind of thought - " I start to say, as Adora says,

"I just thought it was the hair - "

We both stop, and then I snort a little laugh and she laughs the *exact* same laugh.

"Fuck, there really are two of you," Catra murmurs, and I can't see her face but I just assume she's grinning. I pull her a little closer with the arm I have around her waist, duck my head down and press a kiss to the side of her face, smiling at the warm affection in her commentary.

I flick my eyes up at Adora.

She grins at me, and I grin back.

It feels like we've reached some sort of understanding, at least in terms of touching Catra.

I’m starting to feel confident and in control again.

And then it comes crashing down as Catra turns around in my hold, smirking, and starts to pull at my clothes.

“Hey Adora,” she says, tilting her head to make it clearer she’s not talking to me, but rather to the other Adora who is watching from a few feet away, “You *really* want to see just how much muscle you’ve packed on in the last couple years?”

Catra’s clever fingers slip around to my lower back, and I hear the soft *click* of a hidden clasp coming open.

I look back over at Adora, who is speechless and very, very red.

I’m not sure if she’s flustered *for* me - I’m sure as fuck flustered, because, well, who wouldn’t be in the face of Catra when she gets into this mood - or if she’s maybe letting her mind race ahead to where this night could end up going, the way I’ve been trying very hard not to.

“This okay?” Catra asks me, when neither I nor the other Adora says anything.

“I - yeah,” I stammer, pulling my attention back to her. There’s that worried tension around her eyes. I focus in on Catra, feeling instantly guilty for causing that expression, and cradle her face in

one hand, kissing at her eyebrows, trying to melt away that tension. “I’m fine with it as long as Adora is. It’s not, y’know, like anybody here has never seen it before.”

I say that, but I know this is different.

“Yeah, of course, it’s, yeah, psh,” Adora says, and her false bravado and paper-thin facade of nonchalance is so, so obvious to my ears even as I’m keeping my eyes trained on Catra that I suddenly understand why everybody always tells me I’m a terrible actor. “Totally just like, a super normal thing, uh-huh, yep, that’s. That’s just fine.”

Catra and I exchange a private glance. She raises her eyebrows, as if to say, *Do you see yourself? Seriously. This is you.*

I grin back sheepishly, holding back an embarrassed laugh.

Her unspoken teasing softens to a smile; she gets up on tiptoes and kisses me once, gently, and then pulls away to go to the other Adora.

“You’re being ridiculous,” Catra tells her, firmly and full of love, and even though it’s not directed at me the words bring my nervous flittering in my body down several notches. It seems to have the same effect on Adora, because her jaw unclenches and her shoulders relax visibly.

“This whole day has been a little ridiculous,” Adora says quietly.

“Mm,” Catra agrees, and kisses her. Then she steps back and, in one swift motion, unbuckles her pants and pushes herself out of the rest of her clothes.

My eyes linger hungrily on the curve of her ass, my breath caught in my throat.

“I’m getting in the bed,” Catra announces. “I want you to come cuddle me, both of you, and you can be as dorky about it as you want as long as you end up in this bed with me.”

Then, utterly naked, utterly captivating, and so, so damn pleased with herself, Catra slides between the sheets - artfully allowing them to pool around her waist - and then crosses her arms behind her head and watches us, *waiting.*

I send a look over at Adora. She looks back at me.

Her face is an interesting mix of determined, stony seriousness and wicked, playful competitiveness. It would be hard, almost angry if not for the way the very corner of her mouth is turned up in a challenging smirk.

I - huh.

I try to impress the image into my mind, to remember - for however long my consciousness is going to exist, at least - this vision of myself. If earlier I'd wanted to hold her, to protect her, now I find myself looking at her like someone I want to laugh with, to spar, to get to know better.

There's something in the blazing, sharp intensity of that smirk that makes me suddenly realize that I'm a lot more like Catra than I'd thought.

"Ready when you are," Adora growls, still wearing that smirk.

I laugh at her, at the absurdity of her, at the abrupt pivot from halting shyness to cocky swagger and at the fact that it was so smoothly and effortlessly caused by Catra.

And I laugh at myself, because I feel a matching smirk on my own face.

"Go!" I declare - because of *course* we've both decided this is a race - and immediately begin the deeply undignified process of wiggling out of my shoulder armor, shucking the bracers first and then trying to get the heavy metal plate up and over my head. I can hear Adora giggling to herself, low and throaty and genuine, and I feel a flash of fondness for her that I'm too busy to inspect too closely.

There's a loud *CLUNK* as I drop the armor and start working on shimmying out of my tight pants - I look over and Adora has managed to strip off all her top layers and is fighting to get out of her boots, hopping around on one foot while tugging at the other, and now *I'm* the one giggling.

I kick off the pants and my own boots, and then start fighting with my shirt.

"The tiara counts as clothes," Adora declares quickly, as she looks up and realizes I'm close to beating her to being the first one to get naked.

"I'm still gonna win," I say, through the fabric of my shirt as I wrestle it up and over my head, trying not to get it tangled in the aforementioned tiara, which I probably should have taken off first.

"As if," Adora counters gleefully, and then I hear a *thump* followed by her swearing and Catra's squeaky laughter exploding out into the room. I manage to free myself from my shirt and am treated to the sight of Adora sitting on her ass with her pants tangled around her ankles, looking momentarily dazed.

"Looks like I win," I gloat, dropping the shirt and tiara off to the side and tossing my head to get a few long, loose strands of hair out of my face.

And both Catra and Adora are suddenly looking at me *very* intensely.

Catra is smirking, open hunger in her stare.

And Adora - Adora looks utterly *gobsmacked.*

She seems frozen in place, sprawled on the floor with her pants half off, propped up on her arms and a blush crawling down her neck and visible on her bare chest.

I watch her swallow.

I feel - I feel embarrassed, and smug all at once?

Is it like, super self-absorbed to like the idea of your own self being impressed by you?

"Hey beautiful," Catra says to me, her voice filling me up like a sip of something warm on a cold day, reassuring and certain. The fact that she looks at me so fondly, that she can see this form that was made to fight and kill and see a *person,* a person she still wants to treat with soft kindness and call *beautiful* -

"Get in that bed and kiss her," Adora says authoritatively from the floor. I turn my eyes to her, and she's looking at Catra with so much solemn, unvarnished love that I don't hesitate to follow her direction.

I climb into the bed, drawn into Catra and held captive by her eyes, and meet her in the middle to kiss her, and kiss her, and kiss her.

Catra arches up into me, her mouth yielding and greedy all at once, and I balance myself on one arm and tangle my fingers through her hair with my free hand. I feel her fingertips run up the outside of one of my thighs, and goosebumps break out across the skin of my body.

I lose myself in the smell of her, the feel of her, the sound of her, and I barely notice when the bed creaks and sinks down with the addition of a third person.

I *definitely* notice when Catra puts a hand on my shoulder and pushes me, directing me off of her and onto my side. She's deftly moved me where she wants me this way a thousand times before; my body follows the repositioning as automatically as breathing, and I hardly even stop kissing her.

My eyes do flutter open when her hand pulls away, and I see her reach back behind herself and grab Adora's hand, pull her in close.

The realization that Catra is now bracketed by - by two different versions of *me* -

I pause to catch my breath.

"I - are we - is this okay?" I fumble, asking both of them, asking myself.

"I feel a little stupid," Adora confesses from the other side of Catra, hiding her face against the back of Catra's neck. Even her ear, peeking up over the edge of Catra's shoulder, is a vibrant red.

Between us, Catra frowns. She looks from me to Adora, and then from Adora to me.

"Look," she says, carefully, measuredly, "If you're not comfortable with doing anything like this, we can just sleep. But you know it's only *you,* right? I mean it's - it's not like you've never masturbated before." Her careful mask of compassion cracks a little at this last bit, a smirk fighting to manifest on her face.

I feel my face get hot and determinedly do *not* look at Adora, naked on the other side of Catra.

"I - I mean," Adora splutters, "That's, you know, that's different."

“Are you sure?” Catra asks, now smirking in earnest. “Have you checked?”

And then Adora and I accidentally make eye contact.

Her mouth falls open just so as she blinks rapidly, brains apparently as scrambled as mine, struggling to find something to say in response to that.

Her breath is coming hard, and her eyes are half-lidded, and she doesn’t seem to know how to get her mouth to close all the way -

So *this* is what I look like when I’m turned on and trying to hide it.

I’m… I’m really not subtle.

Catra laughs and shakes her head at the both of us.

She lifts a hand and runs it down my arm in a familiar stroking pathway, her thumb whispering along the shape of my bicep, holding my eyes the entire time. She leans in and kisses me, as delicately as a dab from a silk napkin, and then twists around to kiss the other me the same way.

She takes her hand away from my arm, weaves her fingers through the fingers of Adora's hand, and then twists back around and guides that hand across the divide of her own body and over to my side of the bed.

My eyes dance between the two of them as their paired palms come towards me.

In Catra's eyes, a genuine question in a moment of hesitation: *Is this alright with you?*

In Adora's eyes, a question I'm currently asking myself: *What is this going to feel like?*

I lean in closer, pressing my forehead to Catra's and moving my arm to meet those questing palms.

Catra places Adora's hand on my arm and then slips her own away, and then it's just us.

I watch Adora's face - my face - as her fingers explore the shape of the muscle there.

It really is *so* different from looking in a mirror. From this angle, wrapped around Catra and loosely draped in blanket, she looks like a person I've never seen before. Obviously that's *me,* obviously I've seen what I look like plenty of times before, but -

But it’s different, when her touch is so tentative, and her expression is so nervous and uncertain and desperate with the desire not to do anything wrong.

I imagine reaching across Catra to touch her in return, and I feel a hot twist of something complicated and confusing inside of my core.

We look at each other, then, and I think maybe I’m seeing myself in a way I’ve never seen *anybody* before, because so much of what’s in her face is *me,* but not me, and to be outside of myself like this but also feel so, so sure that I know her more intimately than it’s possible to know another person -

She smiles.

I smile back at her.

“This is so weird,” she whispers, but she doesn’t take her hand off of my arm.

“It’s *so* weird,” I agree.

I graze my fingertips along the elbow of her outstretched arm.

Her eyes flutter shut and her breath catches.

"This okay?" I whisper.

It's just arms. We're just touching each other's arms.

"Yeah," she says, face scrunching thoughtfully and then her eyes coming back open again. "Yeah. This is okay."

It's okay.

It's. Honestly kind of cool.

Kind of *fascinating.*

I glance over at Catra, and the utter triumph on her face makes me laugh suddenly.

"What are you looking so happy about, huh?" I say, turning my head in towards her and rubbing my nose playfully against her cheek.

I slip my hand off of Adora's elbow and instead wrap my arm around Catra, no longer self-conscious about the fact that this brings my arm into contact with Adora's naked stomach in addition to Catra's.

"Look," Catra says, laughter in her eyes, "I know this day has been kind of emotionally intense for you, I don't want to downplay that, but this is - I would be lying if I said I'd never fantasized about this. Of course I'm fucking happy to be in the middle of an Adora sandwich."

Adora laughs, as do I.

Following my lead, Adora withdraws her hand from my bicep and wraps her arm around Catra's waist too.

"What now?" Adora asks. "We've got you completely trapped."

"We'd have won the war *way* sooner if we'd had this trick up our sleeve," I add, smirking.

"If two of you came charging at me on the battlefield I'd probably assume I had a concussion," Catra snickers. "And y'know, if you're asking for… *suggestions* in terms of what now, well." She wiggles in our grasp, and my breath catches in my throat as she resettles with her ass in my groin and then tugs my hand up to rest on her breast.

“Fuck, Catra,” I hear Adora growl, low and animalistic, and from the way Catra’s started slowly rocking her hips I have a strong suspicion she’s put one of her thighs between Adora’s.

“Mhm,” Catra purrs, “That is - “ the sound of a kiss - “ - exactly - “ *kiss* - “ - what I had in mind.” I hear a desperate groan come from deep in Adora’s chest, and wonder just what Catra did to make it happen. “Don’t make me beg for it, Adora.”

I feel myself smirking.

I feel like it’s only fair, after all, that I help my other self to turn the tables.

“Maybe we *should* make you beg for it,” I murmur against Catra’s ear, grasping at the breast she’s so conveniently placed my hand on, gently seizing her nipple and teasing it with soft pulsing squeezes as I kiss my way up her neck. She gasps and trembles against me, and the intensity of her reaction is a damn good indication of just how turned on this whole idea has her.

“Oh, fuck,” she whines, and then her words are swallowed by another series of intense, heated kisses as Adora leans forward and uses my distraction to claim the upper hand.

Adora catches my eye in between kisses and we smirk at each other.

Driving Catra wild, giving her everything she wants, and getting to show off in the process?

Now that's something I know for a fact I'm completely comfortable and confident doing.

We trap Catra between our bodies, between our kisses, between our hands.

She keens with delight, with surprise, maybe, at how quickly we've shifted to working together to be her undoing.

I kick the sheets down and off our bodies, already too warm and wanting to see what I'm doing, and then hook one of my legs around Catra's and use it to part her thighs.

"Fuck," I murmur hungrily as the smell of sex hits the air, "Just how wet are you already?" Adora makes a gutteral noise of agreement without slowing her ravenous kissing. I watch the movement of muscle and sinew across her torso as her hand goes questing downwards, taking advantage of my leg pulling Catra's open.

Catra makes the most incredible noise in response, and I chuckle between her shoulder blades, still teasing one of her nipples and now grinding my hips against her ass. I can feel her tail flicking twitchily between my thighs - she must already be feeling pretty overwhelmed.

Adora pulls her face away, sucking her lower lip thoughtfully into her mouth and smirking as she focuses on what she's doing with her hand and on enjoying Catra's reaction to it.

She looks… incredible like that?

She catches me looking and I cover the brief moment of stunned desire with a suggestive smirk.

"You thinking what I'm thinking?"

What *I'm* thinking is that right about now I want nothing more in the world than to have my head between Catra's thighs and my fingers inside of her right up to the knuckle, and from the way Adora raises an eyebrow and then flicks her gaze pointedly down the bed, she and I are very much on the same page.

"I think so, yeah," Adora growls, and smirks back at me.

I shuffle back in the bed, disentangling myself from Catra; her eyes flick open and dart over to me, and she starts to say

something that is very quickly interrupted by Adora putting a palm on her hip bone and pushing her over onto her back and then climbing down to settle between her legs.

"Oh, fuck, Adora," Catra whines, before either of us have even touched her.

I move over, planning to trap that nipple I'd been teasing in the heat of my mouth instead of with my fingers, but Catra intercepts me and draws my face in for a gasping, toothy kiss. I moan, jagged and involuntary, and hear a surprised sounding huff of noise from Adora behind me.

(Is she as fascinated by the sound of my moaning as I am by the sound of hers?)

I run my hands up and down Catra's chest as I kiss her. When she starts to gasp into my mouth and arch against me, I flick my eyes briefly down and confirm that Adora has her face between Catra's legs, eyebrows bunched in concentration, the shadows dancing along her back and shoulder muscles hinting at the hidden movement of her arm.

I return my attention to Catra, cupping her face in my palm, and she whines and grasps at my arms.

"You look so good like this," I whisper to her, letting the thought roll unimpeded from my lips as soon as I think it. Catra whimpers,

trying to pull me in for another kiss, and I toy with being mean and denying it to her but I can't, I *can't,* because I love her too much, and she's already clearly coming undone. I kiss her and then, as I'm doing that, I pin both her hands above her head.

"Fff-f-fuck," she whispers, as our lips pull apart and I grin down at her.

"How many times do you think you can come for me?" I purr, holding both her wrists with one of my hands and slipping my free one to toy once more with her breast. "What's our record? Three back to back? I think with two of me we should at least be able to get you to four." Catra makes a wordless, luxuriously desperate sound at this, arching her body, trembling beneath me.

With a smile, I lower my head and take her nipple between my teeth.

Catra swears again, *loudly,* caught between my mouth and hand on top and the mouth and hand of the other me on the bottom.

It doesn't take long before her writhing turns to shaking and she's coming hard for us.

"Don't stop," I tell Adora, and then latch my mouth back onto Catra's undoubtedly now very sensitive nipple. I trust Catra to tell us to stop if she needs us to for whatever reason. I trust my other self to obviously listen, if that happens.

It feels good, actually, how completely I trust Adora. Have I ever trusted myself like that before now, now that she's kind of, at least temporarily, another person?

I know myself and that means I know her, and I know she would never, ever do anything to hurt Catra in any way. It's completely out of the question, so there's no reason to worry about it.

Instead of worrying, I indulge in the sound and feel of Catra beneath me, gasping and writhing and swearing in between bouts of wordless keening as she shakes and clenches tightly as another peak hits her.

"Good girl," I whisper breathily around her nipple, still keeping her wrists pinned to the pillow, allowing her to throw herself against my strength with all her might to have some kind of outlet for everything she's feeling.

I count the cycles of deep, resonating groans followed by taut, trembling silence until I'm pretty sure we're at number four, and then when she falls limp again after the most recent orgasm I withdraw my hands and mouth, sit back on my heels, and get a good look at her.

She's… so beautiful. I love her so much.

Her hair is plastered to her forehead with sweat, her mouth is half open, her eyes closed. Aftershocks of little tremors pulse visibly through her limbs, and I glance down her heaving, overwhelmed body to see Adora propped up on her elbows between Catra's thighs, smiling an impossibly soft smile as she rests her cheek against the inside of one of Catra's legs.

Wow.

So -

So *that's* what Catra sees, when I'm helplessly adrift in how much I love her and don't care how openly it shows on my face.

As if she feels me looking, Adora turns those eyes up to me, and they catch in the light and dance with a dozen unspoken things, glistening like the surface of the ocean as it tosses moonlight from crest to crest.

Pretty. I'm *pretty.*

I -

I've never really *believed* anybody, when they've told me stuff like that. That I'm beautiful. That I'm… pretty.

But then, I've never seen myself quite like this.

Adora's smile doesn't falter, but it becomes quizzical.

"Come here," I say to her, matching the smile and flicking my gaze back to Catra.

We have a partner very much in need of snuggling, right now. I can pull apart these weird feelings about my self-image later.

"Mmm," Catra groans, as Adora shimmies up in the bed and joins us back at pillow level, "Mine."

I don't have to wonder which of us she means as she pulls me close with one grasping hand and Adora with the other.

Both. We're both hers.

Completely and utterly.

"How was that?" I murmur into the back of one silky soft ear and she settles in happily between us. A purr starts up against my chest, and Adora looks across at me and grins just a little smugly.

“Good,” Catra manages to say, her face hidden in the curve of Adora’s neck. “Real good. Real - *real* good.”

I grin - probably with a matching bit of smugness to go with the other me’s expression - and kiss the back of her neck right as Adora kisses her forehead. Catra makes a tiny, sweet squeak of a noise.

“Two kisses,” she says, dazed and delighted as she rides the afterglow of the moment. There’s another little noise I think might be a giggle. Wow. She must be super floaty right now. “Do that again?”

I look up at Adora as she looks up at me, and we share a smile.

Nobody could possibly understand how much I love Catra in moments like this.

Nobody, of course, except *myself.*

“Anything you want,” Adora says, low and a little hoarse, and I couldn’t agree more.

Slow and tender and unashamed, we press soft kisses to Catra’s face and neck and ears and shoulders, and her rumbling purr is almost loud enough to drown out the whispering noises of pleasure each kiss evokes.

The three of us are pressed so close that a little bit of touching between Adora and I is inevitable, but it no longer feels awkward. How could it, after what we just shared? After what we're sharing now?

Just when the deep rise and fall of her breathing has me thinking Catra's fallen asleep in our arms, she smiles and her eyes flutter open.

She rolls over to her back and looks up at each of us, then takes my hand in her right and Adora's in her left. With quiet reverence, she draws each hand to her mouth one after the other, kissing Adora's knuckles, and then mine.

"Thank you," she says, all sincerity.

I grin, leaning in to kiss her brow.

"I'm glad," I say, gently. "I'm glad you, uh - didn't let me get caught up in my own head and talk myself into like… sleeping outside or something."

"Tch. I was never going to let you do that," Catra says, sleepy but firm. "Idiot." She fills the word with love, and squeezes my hand with hers. She hesitates, and then, after a moment, asks: "Did you two, uh… like it?"

I look reflexively up at my other self.

She’s blushing.

Fuck. I think I’m blushing too.

I look back down at Catra.

“Yeah,” I say, trying to think of something smooth, something suave and cool and just a bit aloof, something about how I enjoy literally every opportunity to be intimate with her, and oh fuck is that really what I’m going to call it, ‘being intimate with you’, like some kind of awkward instructional pamphlet, and -

“It was pretty special,” other me says, and oh, thank every star in the sky for her because that is a thousand times more sweet and romantic sounding than whatever was about to spill out of my mouth.

“Yeah,” I say again, and then, with just a smidge of self-aware dorkiness, “Agreed.”

Catra smiles wider.

She slips her hands out of ours, then reaches up and cups my jaw in one palm, Adora's in the other. I wonder how strange this must be for her, for us both to be here at the same time.

Her thumb trailing gingerly, thoughtfully across my lower lip makes me want to close my eyes - makes me remember how wound up I am, to be completely honest - but I keep my gaze on her, watching what looks like an idea forming in that magnificent mind of hers.

"So," Catra ventures, a little smirk touching her lips, "Here's… a thought. What if… I mean… you must be wondering? Right?" She pauses, slides her eyes from me to Adora, from Adora to me. "What it would be like to kiss yourself?"

Heat flares up my neck, floods my face.

I -

I turn my eyes quickly to the other me to gauge her reaction, and she looks as totally flabbergasted as I feel.

But now I'm looking at her mouth, and then I'm watching her gaze drop down as she looks at mine, and -

Well, maybe I hadn't been wondering *consciously* before, but with Catra just boldly putting it out there into the air, of course I'm

going to start wondering *now.*

"I didn't - " Adora splutters, "I didn't really - I mean I guess I - I didn't think that was a - an option? I don't - I don't even know if you'd - you know, be okay with it?"

Oh, I must be *so* red, because Adora looks like maybe she's put in a requisitions form to have all the blood in her limbs and torso reallocated to her neck and face and had it granted at high priority.

And then I realize she's waiting for me to *answer,* and oh fuck, that means I have to figure out how I feel about it, and -

"I - is that - like - is it allowed?" I say, feeling like I'm trying to think using a ball of flower petals and twine instead of an actual brain.

I look at her mouth again.

What *would* it feel like to kiss her?

(Her? Me? Myself?)

"If you're asking *me* for permission," Catra purrs, suddenly sounding *very* coherent again, "I'm gonna go ahead and say yeah, you can kiss yourself." A pause hangs in the air filled with ruddy, smirking pleasure radiating from the woman reclined regally between us. "As long as I get to watch."

Oh. Oh, okay, so that -

That coiling dominance in her voice absolutely has me horny again, and the thought of her watching, supervising as I do something -

Something - something that *feels* forbidden somehow?

Or, maybe not forbidden -

Self-indulgent, I think, might be the right word for it?

"Again - it's not like you've never masturbated before," Catra adds, the words smoky and smug and tugging at my libido like a ripcord.

I hear a little choking noise and I think it came out of the other me until I realize it came out of the *actual, current me.*

“Fuck,” Catra murmurs through a toothy grin, fully in the swing of things now, “You always look so fucking hot when I manage to get you feeling flustered and submissive in your She-Ra form… and now you actually get to *see* it.”

And then, on the heels of those words, I can’t *not* look up and make eye contact with myself.

And oh, *oh,* she’s *looking* at me.

Really looking.

I swallow hard, trying to find my bearings.

It’s Catra’s hand on my face that grounds me, her fingers fondly brushing a stray strand of hair behind my ear that brings me back to somewhere where I can think through this.

“You don’t have to do anything you don’t want to do,” Catra tells both of us, dropping the bossy voice and slipping back to that quiet sincerity.

“I think,” I say, allowing my heart rate to settle slightly into something calmer, “I think I’d like to? I mean I guess I am… y’know… kinda curious? If - “ I look up at Adora. “If it’s okay with you?”

"Yeah," she says, holding my eyes, and I'm amazed by how reassuring her solid, sure voice is, by how comforting her steady eye contact is, "I think I feel the same way. I'm…" She laughs, nervous, self-effacing, but honest. "I *am* curious."

I glance back briefly at Catra, but she just lies back, smiling, watching, offering no further guidance.

I return my eyes to Adora. To my other self.

Heart thumping once more, I lean in.

She leans in too.

We're almost there, her breath on my lips, when the giggles hit.

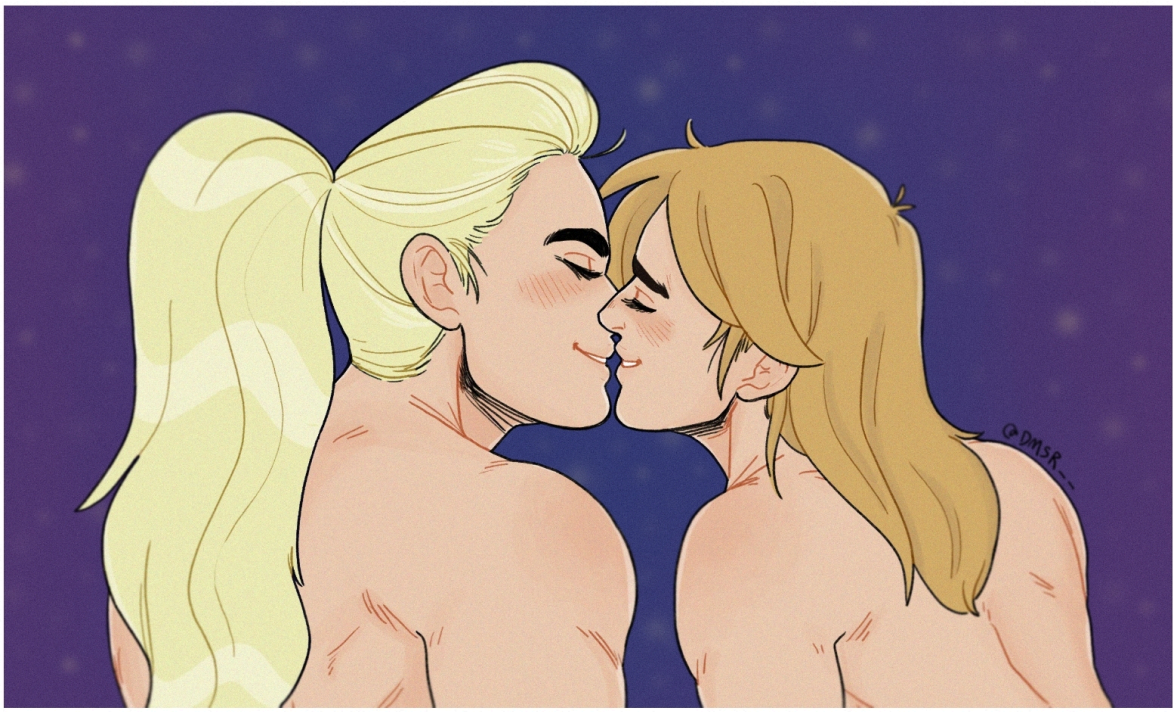
I'm not sure who starts laughing first, whether it's me or her, but instantly we're both cackling with the utter absurdity of the situation.

We collapse on top of Catra, who makes a noise of dismay, and I laugh and laugh and laugh until hysterical tears track across Catra's chest. I can feel Adora's head next to mine, her hair getting in my mouth, her guffawing right in my ear, her great

belly-laughing shaking the bed, and somehow that just makes everything funnier.

We laugh until we're wheezing for breath, and then just when we think we're going to pull it together we laugh a little more.

Eventually it all seems to be out of our system, for the most part, and giggling, snorting, I prop myself up on my arms and Adora grins at me, and ah, there's that joyous sparkle in her eyes again, and -



Artwork by @DMSR__

And I close the distance between us and press my lips to hers, and I feel her smile soften and watch those eyes drift shut and allow mine to do the same, and I *kiss* her.

It's soft and rushed and riding the wave of our giggles, taut with the energy of our shared nervous eagerness.

I'm *kissing myself.*

It's silly, and it's strange, and it's kind of really hot, and I have to stop to press my forehead to hers and laugh breathily again at the absurdity of it, nose to nose as my own giddy guffaw echoes back at me out of Adora's lips.

She laughs, and kisses me, and laughs some more, and it's her smile, her sweet, nervous, self-effacing grin that tugs at something inside of me and wants to really just *keep* kissing her - beyond just an experiment, beyond just doing something wacky and titillating because Catra asked us to.

Because the way she cups my jaw makes me want to protect her from anything bad the world might throw at her, the way her nerves show in the scrunch of her eyebrows and the uncertain flash of her smile makes me want to kiss away every ounce of her self-doubt and make her understand that she isn't doing anything wrong.

Because there's something kind and wise and knowing and so damn intelligent in her eyes when she holds my stare and meets my scrutiny, and I've never -

I've never been able to admire the storm blue of her eyes from so close that I can see the darker ring of charcoal at the outer edges of the iris, the quiet, complex dance of steely cobalt and warm feathery grey - and in the same close, warm look, the faint ghostly freckles across the bridge of her nose, the curl of her eyelashes -

"You're staring," Adora whispers, like she can't quite believe it, like this, in itself, is more surprising than the fact that we kissed, were kissing - probably will be kissing again shortly, if all goes well -

And then I'm laughing again at myself for getting myself worked up and invested and hopeful about the thought of fucking *kissing myself.*

"Yeah," I say, reaching out and taking her face in my hand, marveling at how much of her cheek my palm encompasses, and holding her gently like that as I lean in and press a kiss between her eyebrows. She hums with laughter of her own, bemused but willing.

"What for?" She asks, and I can hear the smile in her question even as I briefly shut my eyes and breathe in. The scent of her right at the edge of her hairline is pleasantly strong - a brief, unexpected whiff of *Adora* that catches me off guard with how it's both familiar and a totally new way of experiencing myself.

Not exactly like I can usually smell my own hairline.

The thought gets me grinning again.

"I dunno, it's just - it's cool? You know?" I pull my mouth away from her forehead and look into her eyes again, find her gaze searching mine. "I don't normally get to see myself like this." I pull my hand away from her face, suddenly sheepish, unsure if she's comfortable with the way I've been presumptuously touching her.

"Yeah," she says, her smile flickering from small to broad and back again, like she's embarrassed by the big grin she's clearly trying to suppress. "It is kinda neat."

I watch her eyes flick down to my mouth again and then back up to my eyes.

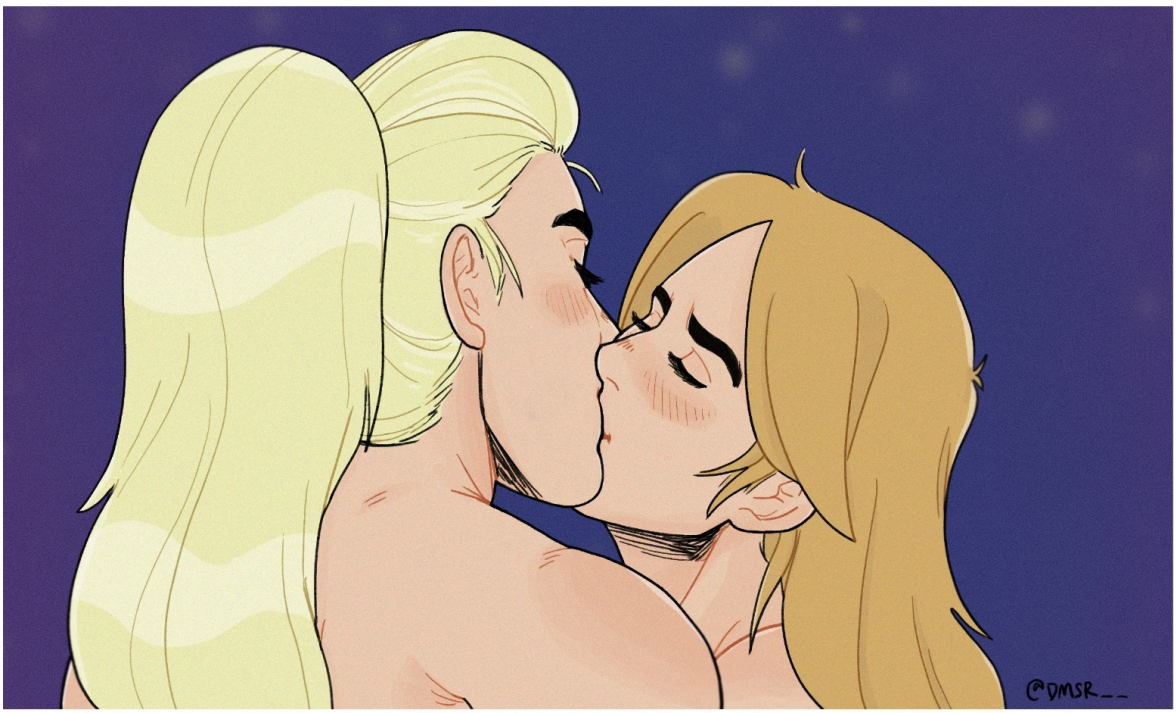
And then *she* leans in and kisses me.

She comes in slow, unlike the way we crashed into each other a moment ago, and I know - because I know myself - that she's doing it like that to give me the chance to stop her if I don't want to keep going.

It’s just something I expect of myself, but… when it’s coming from someone else, it strikes me as thoughtful. Respectful.

I lean in towards her and answer the question.

Yes.



Artwork by @DMSR__

A sound catches my attention from elsewhere in the bed.

It’s - oh, it’s Catra.

I steal one more kiss and then pull away to turn and look at Catra, and -

Fuck, Catra is so gorgeous. It strikes me like it always does, the way she looks splayed out in our bed, naked and smug and still wearing the sweaty, sex-tinged daze of her last orgasm.

She grins down at us, her arms crossed behind her head, propped up against the pillows and looking like the king of the entire damn universe.

"Oh, don't stop on my behalf," she purrs, raising an eyebrow and sliding one of her legs up, bending her knee and giving us both an eyeful of her still-slick inner thighs.

It is, as ever, a *wildly* inviting sight.

And it serves as a pretty fucking vivid reminder that *I* haven't gotten off yet when my clit throbs in response to the deliciously shameless view.

"Wow," Catra murmurs, her eyes flicking back and forth between the two of us, a flush rising in her cheeks, "It's kind of intense having *two* of you look at me like that."

“Like what?” Adora croons, her voice brimming with hunger that seems to perfectly match my own.

Catra recollects her composure and smirks back at Adora.

“You know *exactly* like *what.”*

“Like I want to climb back up in between those legs,” Adora suggests in a low, growling whisper, “and get my mouth on you again?”

My body responds to her tone of voice, a pulse of throbbing starting up between my thighs.

“You made me come *five* times in a row,” Catra rebuffs, grinning. “You’re gonna have to give me a little more downtime than that before you come anywhere near me with that damn mouth of yours.” She smirks, growling this last bit in a way that makes heat coil anew between my legs.

Without really thinking, I find myself settling my hand on Adora’s lower back.

She looks over, raises her eyebrows at me, and -

And I really, really like the way she's looking at me.

"What're you thinking about?" I ask her, and I can hear the way the question comes out throaty and smirking even when I didn't mean to make it quite so suggestive.

I watch as Adora's eyes flick down over my body and then back up.

"Remember the first time we met Huntara?" She says, quietly.

I do. I do remember very clearly.

"The dream we had that night?" I say, raising my own eyebrows as I make a guess at what she's hinting at.

"Yeah," she says, hushed but intense.

"That was a good dream."

"It was. Yeah."

I feel another throb, and I swallow hard.

She doesn’t want to ask me for it because of course it seems like an impossible thing to ask for, but -

Well. Her wildest, most secret fantasies aren’t a secret from me because they’re *my* wild, secret fantasies too.

“We could try it,” I suggest quietly, sending a quick, curious glance at Catra to find she’s watching this exchange with *intense* interest.

(We’ve never told her about that dream we had about Huntara.)

“You’d be okay with that?” Adora asks me, and I can see how excited and eager she is, eager enough that she’s having to fight down the enthusiasm to be cautious and double check with me.

“We know our own safe words,” I point out, grinning, and that makes her grin right back at me. “I - yeah. I want to do that.” I want to do this for her. I want to do this for *me.*

Adora’s grin slides into a smirk.

“Come and get me, then,” she growls, wiggling away from the hand I have on her back. I bark a sharp laugh because I *know* she doesn’t stand a chance, not when I put my mind to it, and

somehow that confidence blends into a delicious, hot variety of arousal I've never felt before.

Rough. I can be *rough* and trust that it's wanted, trust that my partner can take it.

I clamber across the bed in a flash, and with another burst of laughter Adora and I are soon wrestling, fighting with absolute sincerity. I start going easy but she gives *everything,* forcing me to meet her at her level, and the very act of having to actually use my muscles to overwhelm this wild hurricane of a woman fills me with a thrill of anticipation.

I pin her and she fights free, gasping and panting and grinning, and so I grab her again, grab harder, grab tighter, put more effort into holding her down. She thrashes against me, still with that delighted, competitive grin, and I watch as her neck and chest go pink and then red with exertion, teeth gritted in a gleeful snarl as she fights me.

"You're strong," she gasps, when I finally manage to keep her in a hold for more than a few seconds.

"So are you," I say, in all seriousness kind of surprised by how hard it was to trap her even with all my She-Ra strength. Then I allow my face to slide into smug superiority. "But I'm stronger."

“Think you can keep me down?” She bites back, and then, before I can retort, makes a renewed attempt to get free - but I’ve already tightened my grip on her before she finishes the question, because I’m intimately familiar with that particular tone of voice and the way it means trouble is brewing.

“I *know* I can keep you down,” I purr into her ear, employing all my strength to keep her firmly held against the mattress. As I clamp my fingers down hard around her wrists, holding them above her head, I hear her breath catch. “And I know that’s what you want. You want to be overpowered. You don’t want a *choice.”* The words pour out of me, no pause to think about them before they roll off my tongue, and Adora whimpers beneath me at the penetrating, inescapable truth of them. “You want to be allowed to just take what you’re given. To enjoy it, to surrender to it because surrender is the *only* option.” I move my mouth close to her ear, graze my teeth against the shell of it and relish the way I can feel her breath hot against my shoulder. “I know I’m right.”

She makes a soft noise that fills me with something like pride, something like hunger, something like love.

It’s a fantasy come true at the hands of someone who knows *exactly* how she’s always dreamed of it playing out, and well -

I’ve always been a sucker for the thrill of giving Catra everything and anything she’s secretly fantasized about. I guess I shouldn’t be surprised it turns me on to do the same for another partner, even if that partner is *me.*

“Keep going?” I ask, gently, breaking character with my voice if not with my body.

“Yes,” Adora confirms breathily, and I turn my head to look at her - her cheeks are red, her eyes are dazed with hunger, and I can’t help but feel a little smug about having done that, even if it’s not really hard to know your own turn-ons.

“Anything you *don’t* want me to do?” I push, because we both know where this fantasy goes and I want to make sure we’re on the same page here before we both get too flustered to think.

Pinned underneath me, Adora seems to give this genuine thought, like she’s running through the choreography and checking each step for anything that might not translate well from saucy daydream to actual activity - which is, honestly, exactly what I’m doing.

“No,” she says, after a moment. “I’m - I’m good with any of it, if you are. I mean, you don’t - you don’t have to. No obligation.”

I grin.

“I want to,” I say, and I think she understands why, because she nods, the flicker of a knowing smirk at the corner of her mouth.

“Keep going?” She asks.

"Whenever you're ready," I say, and I've barely gotten the words out of my mouth before the brewing smirk flashes into a full one and she's struggling again, muscles bulging, tendons taut and visible as she fights and strains and makes me work to keep her down.

I laugh darkly, and keep her in place, and grind my hips against hers.

"You're not going *anywhere,"* I growl, swapping my hold on her wrists so that I have one hand free. I pin one of her thighs down against the bed with one of my own and marvel at the flex and ripple of sturdy, compact muscle as she tries to throw me off. She *is* strong. I find myself impressed and a little distracted by it.

Then I rally my focus, sharpen my own smirk, and put my hand between her legs.

She *gasps* in surprise as I find that familiar part, slick with the night's steady build of arousal, and I allow myself to touch. I'm gentle, at first, and she whines in frustration at the softness of my exploration.

Like masturbating, but different - the power to push yourself past barriers you normally can't overcome because you're lost in the haze of your own physical pleasure, the ability to make that imagined hand or mouth into a real one that does exactly what you were longing for.

She's wet, fuck, but *I'm* wet too.

"You're tough," I murmur, "But I can break you."

Adora groans beneath me, bucking her hips, sliding herself against my fingers, and I know how deliciously hot those words must sound to her because I've imagined them dozens of times before while I touched myself.

"Now show me just how much you can handle," I say, and without any further preamble drive two of my fingers inside of her, relishing the unhinged, desperate cry of pleasure she makes. I'm not worrying about being too rough - being too rough is the *point.* It's part of the fantasy.

And fuck, it's kind of hot to be *allowed* to be too rough, to trust my other self to be able to take it and to enjoy it without reservation.

She feels good around my fingers, and it's so much easier to get the perfect angle for thrusting into her since I'm, well, in a separate body. I'm grinning, I realize, as I pin her down and fuck her in a way I know she's always wanted to experience being fucked.

“You don’t have to try to pretend you don’t like it,” I murmur, slamming into her, feeling for how slick she is and how tight and thinking about how soon I can add a third finger without actually hurting her. “I know *exactly* what you want.”

As Adora moans at the words, I hear a sharp little inhale from beside me.

I cast a quick glance over at Catra and -

Ffffuck, Catra is - she’s *touching herself* watching this.

A blaze of arousal roars through me at the sight, and I nearly lose my rhythm.

Then I realize I can use that against the *other* me.

“Look at Catra,” I command, and as Adora’s eyes slide open and her head turns -

“Fu - “ she starts to groan, and I push the third finger inside of her, and the groan becomes a rough, loud keen - “Fuuu-huuuuck!”

Her legs are already shaking. Fuck, I’m a little jealous.

A little jealous, and a lot smug.

"It's okay to give in," I rasp against her ear, holding strong against her surge of resistance, knowing how much the thought of being completely outmatched turns me - and her - on. She's not going *anywhere.* As she falls slack again after another failed attempt to struggle free, she whines and whimpers and looks up at me, mouth open, eyes glazed, brows clenched. "There you go," I murmur, filling the words with praise, with affection, and with no small amount of self-satisfied preening. "I'm in charge. That's all there is to it."

Adora whimpers again, and I feel her clench around my fingers. Fuck, it's kind of incredible - being able to give someone one of their deepest desires, right down to every little detail.

I want so badly to make her come undone, because I know how much *I* want that - I know the layers and layers of stress and insecurity that I wear every day, and I know the incredible catharsis of getting to shed them.

"You know I've got you," I say, the reassurance heavy on my breath as I fuck her roughly and steadily on three of my fingers, "You know you don't have anything to prove. Give in." I'm distantly aware of the sound of Catra's choked gasps and huffs in the bed beside us as she gets herself off to the sight of us.

I almost want to laugh - so much for Catra needing a breather.

Adora groans and bucks and writhes underneath of me, her thighs shaking under the crushing weight of mine. She needs more before she can let go completely, I know.

"Give in," I say again, and then, as I forcibly press her legs apart with mine, "You don't have a *choice."*

I don't think I've ever been this rough with Catra before - I've definitely never gotten this intense with the dirty talk. I'd have to be really, *really* damn sure she was comfortable with it before I'd even suggest playing at something like this.

I'm briefly distracted by the sudden fear that Catra will be a little freaked out to learn that I'm excited by the thought of being talked to like this sometimes, but then -

But then Adora is coming underneath of me, coming with my fingers buried as deep inside of her as they'll go, moaning low and urgent and shaking uncontrollably, and my attention is pulled entirely back to her.

"Good girl," I say, knowing she needs those words, knowing she wants those words, knowing they mean the world to her in this moment. "Good girl. Good girl. That's it, that's exactly it. You're good. You're so good, so good, Adora." My own name forms organically on my lips like something precious, something completely natural, like morning dew on a blade of grass - something that's just *meant* to be there. In this moment of total

vulnerability, I'm not just going through the motions of giving her the reassurance I know I would want.

I love her. I love her because she's mine, because I'm hers, because I'm all she has and she's all I have, because I *am* her, and I trust her, and in this moment, I can keep her and protect her and treasure her in a way I'd never have been able to when we were just one person in one body and one mind.

I know her better than I know anybody else in the world, even Catra, and maybe it isn't so terrible to look at the whole of her and decide that she *is* good, she *is* deserving of tenderness and care and compassion.

Gently, gently, I release her from the hold I've had her in. I climb around her so that now she's the one in the middle, me on one side and Catra on the other, and as she curls in on herself I wrap my body around hers and pull her in towards my chest.

Adora makes a quiet noise of surprise and then sighs into me.

Mm. She's *soft.*

Just like that, all the hard contours of her body relax into fuzzy watercolor gestures. I wrap my arms around her and kiss her sweaty forehead, and she mumbles something against my chest.

“What’s that?” I ask, genuinely curious.

“I said you’re *big,”* she says blearily, burrowing into my hold and tucking her head under my chin. I feel a little pang in my chest. Catra gets like this sometimes, and -

I mean -

I guess I’d never really imagined I could be like Catra is in those moments. Delicate, affectionate, snuggly. It always feels so sluggish and embarrassing from my end when I’m in that kind of mental state, but -

There’s nothing embarrassing about this at all. It’s… sweet.

Reminded of Catra, I look up to see how she’s doing just in time to see her bring herself to another orgasm - number six of the night, I’m pretty sure - and admire the sight of her face as she does, brows furrowed, head thrown back into the pillows.

When she slowly, shakily opens her eyes again, I’m still looking at her face, smiling at her as I hold my other self safely in my arms while she recovers.

“You enjoy that?” I ask her, trying to keep that flutter of fear out of my question - fear that seeing me act out something kind of

rough and intense might have made her uncomfortable in some way.

We're going to have to talk about it at some point, I suspect.

"Hah," Catra huffs, her chest heaving as she tries to catch her breath, grinning at the both of us, "Yeah - what - what gave it away?"

I smirk, hum thoughtfully, and then reach out my hand to wordlessly ask for one of hers. She obligingly twines her fingers with mine, and I tug her in closer so that she's snuggled up against Adora's back, and then I take one of her still-slick fingers, put it in my mouth, and suck on it slowly and luxuriously without breaking eye contact.

It's Catra's turn to whimper, and at the sound I see Adora, exhausted and spent as she is, grin reflexively between us without opening her eyes.

I pull Catra's finger out of my mouth and then, smirking again, answer:

"That was definitely *one* clue."

Catra makes a noise in the back of her throat and then snuggles in even closer.

"You're way too smug," she grumbles. "Somebody's gotta make *you* come so you stop having more brain power than the rest of us."

"Uh huh," Adora agrees from between us, punctuating that statement by kissing my chest - the spot I always think of, on some level, as *where the failsafe is* even though it's long gone - and then rolling over to capture Catra's mouth in a lazy, sloppy kiss.

I watch the two of them kissing in their mutual state of afterglow bliss and I feel, somehow, like I'm enormously fortunate to get to witness this moment of raw intimacy.

Curled protectively around the two of them like this as they bask in each other without pretense, without armor, without magic, without war, I can see something impossibly special.

Two people. Just two people in love.

Not heroes who saved the galaxy. Not champions of justice or leaders of the rebellion.

Two women who adore each other, and just want to be allowed to keep doing that for the rest of their lives, whatever that may entail.

I’ve never been normal.

I’ve never been *allowed* to be normal.

But this - in this moment -

This looks normal. This *feels* normal.

It’s the most mundane, ordinary thing in the universe.

And it’s more than I could ever have possibly dreamed I’d ever get to have.

As the two of them slow in their kisses, I watch Catra’s eyes come back open dreamily and then settle on me. She smiles, and I smile back at her.

“Take as long as you need,” I say, looping my arm across Adora and Catra both, holding my other self and my love in one loose, fond embrace. “There’s no rush.”

“You’re not getting out of it,” Adora mumbles, flicking her gaze in my direction and flashing me a little smirk. Even in her sluggish

state, there's a piercing kind of understanding in that glance. She knows perfectly well that I'm telling myself not to be selfish, to be patient, to prioritize their pleasure and comfort over my own. "Gonna make you feel *so* good," she says, taking my wrist in one hand and pulling it up towards herself, trapping my forearm between her and Catra's chests, kissing my knuckles.

"You say that like it's a threat," I counter, wondering at how she can hold me like this, at how she can find a way to look at these hands of She-Ra's and let go of the weirdness of all of this and see only a hand she wants to kiss, each touch of her mouth a soft, appreciative *thank you.*

"Gonna getcha," she announces, and Catra giggles and presses in closer to her.

"Have a little nap first," I suggest wryly.

I say there's no rush, but there's a little voice in the back of my mind that isn't sure if that's true. Entrapta said we'd only have, what, eighteen hours? How long ago did she say that? I've lost track.

"You're thinking," Catra declares, snapping me out of my inner thoughts and pulling me away from the temptation to start wondering yet again what will happen when I re-merge with Adora.

(Will I just vanish?)

Adora turns over and looks at me.

“Yep,” Adora says, “She’s thinking.”

“Quit that,” Catra says, reaching across Adora and twining her fingers in my hair, brushing it back and then cradling my jaw with that same hand. I allow my eyes to flutter shut as she repeats the motion a few times, enjoying the feeling of her claws so gingerly grazing my scalp.

“You fixed the thinking problem,” Adora says to Catra in a low, conspiratorial voice. “For now.”

“Got any ideas on a longer-lasting solution to that problem?” Catra chuckles wryly, and my body responds to that tone of voice with the crackle of flame growing higher in my core even as I’m relaxing into Catra’s gentle touch. I keep my eyes closed, but I smile and turn my head to kiss her palm as it goes by.

I want this. I want her. I want *them.*

I make the active decision to *let* myself want.

After all, I didn't even think twice about my other self wanting to have her desires fulfilled.

"How are you two not completely exhausted?" I tease, breathing through my want, allowing it to exist without feeling guilty about it.

"I just need a minute," Adora mumbles, smiling. I feel her calloused fingers graze idly down my hip, feel the answering prickle of arousal rushing along my skin. I can hear that competitive edge in her voice even through her current state of bleary satisfaction, and -

Well. Maybe I'm kind of looking forward to getting to experience being on the other end of that stubborn pride I know so well.

Catra smiles sleepily over Adora's shoulder at me and then turns to trail lazy kisses up Adora's neck without breaking eye contact. Adora squirms a little, her eyes sliding shut and a smile pulling at her lips, and - after just a *moment* of hesitation - I listen to the impulse I feel and duck my head down to kiss her as well, pressing my lips to her hairline, tightening my hold to pull both her and Catra a little closer to me.

Adora huffs in surprise, her smile growing wider and her eyes coming open. She turns in my arms, away from Catra and back to facing me, and I watch her gaze turn thoughtful.

“You’re so gentle,” she remarks, and it takes me a second to realize she’s talking to *me* and not to Catra. I laugh a little self-consciously.

“Me? You mean the one who just held you down and fucked you senseless?” I smirk, resting my mouth against her forehead, enjoying the closeness. It’s already starting to feel natural and comfortable with her.

“Yeah, because you knew that was exactly what I wanted,” she counters, moving her hand from my hip up to my jawline, touching idly at the sweaty, wispy hairs at the base of my neck. “I mean. You know how it’s - how it feels when we’re She-Ra like this.”

I know exactly what she means.

We’re both intimately familiar with this strange blend of feeling like the purest, most undistilled version of myself - more powerful, more charismatic, more *attractive* - but at the same time like a weapon, like a tool, like something too big, too dangerous to exist, let alone to be handling something as important to us and as precious as Catra in her most vulnerable state.

“You’re *trying* to be gentle. You’re always trying so hard to be gentle,” Adora whispers, and suddenly her thumb is brushing across my brow, and I feel - I feel inexplicably choked up, overwhelmed by the acknowledgement because -

Well, since when do I ever let myself admit these kinds of things out loud?

It should go unsaid. It should be a secret.

Nobody should know how hard I'm always *trying.*

Because then they'd know that none of this - absolutely none of this - comes naturally to me.

"Hey," Adora says, quietly, softly - *gently.* "It's okay."

"Is it?" I ask, blinking rapidly, fighting back traitorous tears. I just need to get control of my emotions. Why is this hitting me so hard? "I - it's fine." I force a smile, I swallow hard.

Adora raises both eyebrows at me. *I know you,* that look of disbelief says. *Don't lie to me.*

"Adora?" Catra asks from the other side, frowning. "Is something - ?"

Adora cuts her off with a small, soft hand gesture that I know between us tends to mean *I've got this.* She then repositions, bringing us eye to eye, and I have no choice but to face the

earnest sincerity of her stare. I bring my arm back in as she turns, and her hand intercepts mine, weaving our fingers together.

"It's not a bad thing," Adora says. "It's *not* a bad thing to care about being good to other people. And it's not a bad thing for them to know that you care, that you're putting in effort."

I huff a surprised, emotionally loaded laugh.

"Since - " My throat feels so tight. I swallow again. "Since when do we *actually* believe that applies to us?"

"Since about an hour ago," Adora says, with a cautious earnestness, her thumb rubbing idly at the knuckle of my forefinger. I can't look away from her; there's a crease between her eyebrows again, like she's trying to figure out how to say exactly what's in her head. "I'm - it's - it's *different,* when I see it from the outside. When you're - when I'm thinking about you like you're another person. Does that… I don't know, does that make any sense?"

I frown back at her, processing this, comparing it to the things I've caught myself thinking about her since we got back to the bedroom and started really interacting with each other.

(I wonder, absently, if we're making the same face right now.)

“It makes me feel special,” Adora elaborates very seriously, when I don’t say anything immediately, “knowing you care so much. I think - I mean, being on the receiving end of your touches,” she grins wryly, taking my hand and putting it against her face, “ - that we *probably* don’t have to be as careful as we’ve always been with this form. You could… afford to let loose a bit more, I think.”

“I second that,” Catra says, voice full of love. I feel the tip of her tail brush against my shin. I’m… fuck, I don’t know what I did to deserve her.

“But my point was just… that it’s nice.” As Adora says this, she raises my hand to her lips and kisses right where my palm meets my wrist. “And it’s okay that it’s obvious you’re trying.”

“Okay,” I sigh, smiling, feeling a little tension leave my body. The idea of actually internalizing that… I mean. It’s one thing to know that something’s allowed, intellectually, but…

“I know,” Adora says, without me saying it out loud. “We’ve got - “ she laughs a short, bitter laugh. “We’ve got shit to work through around that.” We share a look of total mutual understanding. Catra, too, understands this, and I make sure to include her with a quick glance. Everybody in this bed has memories of a childhood defined by ruthless, endless reminders that it’s wrong to care too much, that it’s weakness to reveal that you care at all about anything other than your mission. “But I guess I just - getting to see you from the outside, I feel like I’ve… kind of had a revelation. And I wanted to share it.”

I feel myself smiling; she smiles back.

There's a sadness there, an intimately shared trauma, but there's hopefulness there too.

Maybe if she can believe it, I can too.

"Thanks," I say, and bump our noses together. She smiles a little wider and reaches up to brush a loose strand of hair out of my face.

"Anytime," she replies.

It's at this point that Catra crawls over her, settling into a small gap between our bodies and then leaning in to kiss our brows, one and then other, back and forth and back and forth.

"Hey," I chuckle, turning my eyes to try to take in how Catra's responding to watching me, well, talk to myself, I guess. I giggle a little as she places her next kiss on my nose. "You get lonely over there?"

"I wanted to kiss you," Catra declares, following up this statement with a kiss to Adora's nose that makes *her* giggle. "So I'm kissing you." She sits back, leaning her weight back onto her heels between us, and smiles. "You both looked like you needed it."

I smile up at her, and this time I can feel that the expression on my face isn't quite so bittersweet.

"Hey," I say, reaching out to run my hand up Catra's stomach, "I love you."

She smiles back at me, one of those rare, extra-special Catra smiles that scrunches her nose and softens her eyes.

"I love you too," she says,the words filled with awe and honesty. Her eyes dance over to Adora. "And you, too."

"I mean, technically I just said it," Adora says, with a goofy grin, propping herself up on her elbows so she can lean forward and press a kiss to Catra's forearm, "But I love you, too."

"Literally *never* get sick of hearing it," Catra mumbles happily, reaching up to run her fingers through Adora's hair, her attention drifting gently back and forth between the two of us.

I feel… good. Relaxed. Safe.

I've *almost* managed to ignore the background crackling of my libido, but then -

Then I notice Adora is looking at me again, and her scrutiny is turned down towards my torso instead of to my face.

She glances up and realizes she's been caught looking, and - ah! My perfect opportunity.

I waggle my eyebrows. It didn't feel right to use the line before, but *now* -

"Like what you see?" I say, grinning wildly.

Catra cackles, and Adora turns red and hides her face in the pillow.

She mumbles something into said pillow.

"What was that?" I tease, smirking.

"She said," Catra translates, looking *very* pleased with herself, "And I quote, *it's not my fault you're fucking ripped."*

I laugh, rolling over onto my back instead of my side, stretching out *very* deliberately and crossing my arms behind my head,

putting on a show. Adora peeks up out of her pillow at the rustle of the bedsheets, and I watch with smug pleasure as her eyes snag on my body.

"You know, Adora," Catra purrs, subtly repositioning again so that there's no barrier between Adora and I, "Those muscles are as much fun to touch as they are to look at."

Adora makes a little flustered noise in the back of her throat. Flustered… hungry… lusty.

"You can if you want to," I say, holding my position, grinning and waiting for her to make a move.

Playing it cool even as my heart starts thudding loudly in my ears.

"I - uh - uhuh. Um," Adora says, her gaze very firmly lodged on my chest. "Yeah?"

"Yeah," I confirm, trying not to let her nervousness infect me.

Her eyes jump up briefly to meet mine for a final check, and then, at my encouraging nod, she shuffles closer.

“I feel so stupid,” she laughs.

“Do you want me to close my eyes?” I suggest. Sometimes it’s easier for me to try new things that make me feel a little silly if Catra’s blindfolded while we do it, so…

“Would you? That - yeah, that would… that would be helpful,” Adora says. I flash her one last grin and then obligingly shut my eyes.

“Just pretend she’s a sexy statue,” Catra adds, cutting casually through the tension and making both of us giggle.

“Is it less weird or *more* weird to grope a statue of yourself instead of a magical copy of yourself?” Adora questions, and as I’m laughing silently at this, my eyes closed, I feel the first tentative touch of her hand on my hip.

“Honestly, probably more weird,” Catra concedes. The sound of her voice as they banter puts me even more at ease, and I relax back into the bed as Adora’s hands slide from my hip to my stomach.

Some of my cocky smug facade slips as the tentative, curious touches trickle up and down my torso.

“What’re you smiling about?” Adora asks me, at about the same moment I realize I’m smiling. Her fingertips trace the sides of my ribcage as she asks this question, drawing lines along the divots between the muscle there.

“I was thinking something felt weird about it, not like in a bad way, just in a different way,” I say, keeping my eyes closed, letting my head sink back into the pillows, grinning. “I realized it’s because you don’t have claws. Your fingers feel so… round? You’re using parts of your hands to touch me that Catra wouldn’t normally.”

I hear Adora make a thoughtful noise, and then there’s a rustling in the bed. I crack open my eyes reflexively, wondering what Catra is doing, and am instantly caught peeking by both of them.

“Hey, eyes closed, you big goober,” Catra admonishes playfully. “Don’t make me get the blindfold.”

That doesn’t sound so terrible, honestly, but I obediently shut my eyes again, smiling still.

“Better,” Catra says, and then I feel her crawl over me to get to my other side so that now it’s my turn to be sandwiched in the middle. I’m about to ask just what she’s up to when I feel her hand join Adora’s in exploring my body, and instead of a question what comes out of my mouth is a fluttering little gasp. “It’s different, huh?” Catra teases, her palm sliding up my left side, Adora’s moving smoothly - confidently, now - down my right.

“A little, yeah,” I breathe, tilting my head back so I’m less tempted to open my eyes and look at them. My heart starts to beat a little harder and my breath comes a little heavier as Catra’s hand delicately fondles one of my breasts, and then Adora’s wanders down to my hip bone. Oh, fuck, I’m - I can feel myself getting turned on again in a way that’ll be entirely obvious to Adora if she keeps following that path.

Adora’s fingers bypass that part of me, though, and instead trail down the muscle of my thigh, circling my knee, and then coming back up the outside of my leg. I exhale shakily, feeling myself throb with how she just barely grazes the edge of coarse, dark hair on her way back up to my stomach, but don’t complain any more than that. I want her to get to touch and explore at her own leisure, want her to set the pace.

Catra moves around again in the bed next to me, but this time I keep my eyes closed - which means I’m not anticipating it when I feel her lips against my neck, my jaw, my ear, and then she whispers:

“You’ll get your turn, Adora. Don’t worry. I’m not going to let you be selfless tonight.”

I pinch my brows together in a desperate frown to keep myself from opening my eyes, biting back a whimper. Catra’s hand is still on my breast, toying lightly with my nipple. Adora’s hand is coming back up again now, exploring the line where my stomach meets my hip, her fingers splaying wide and taking in the shape

of my abdominal muscles, grazing over my skin and leaving warmth in the wake of each inquisitive touch.

Catra chuckles, and from the sound I can tell she's turned her head away to face Adora again.

"Enjoying yourself, princess?"

Adora hums a pleased affirmative.

"I… yeah, I - " Adora starts, and then seems to have to rally before admitting: "I've been wanting to touch you like this all night."

I grin, because, well. I'd have been feeling the exact same way in her place.

"Here," I offer, unfolding my arms from behind my head and lowering them to my sides so that she has access to them, since I know they would have been on my want-to-touch list. With my eyes closed, I don't know exactly where on the bed either Adora or Catra are, and my left arm ends up brushing up against what I know must be Catra's side. I settle my hand on her lower back automatically, stroking my thumb fondly up her spine, and enjoy the way I can feel her purr at the touch.

Wordlessly, Adora moves her hands up my stomach and to my sternum, painting her fingertips along the contours of my collar bone, following that line out to my neck and shoulder.

It's a strange blend of relaxation and arousal, to just lie back and let myself be touched - touched by *multiple* pairs of hands. I… I'm realizing I kind of really like it, and I like the way I can't feel guilty for liking it, since it's something that was specifically requested of me, and not just me being lazy, or a bad partner, or something.

It's my job to just lie back and enjoy this.

Honestly, it's… damn, it's really nice.

Adora's fingers caress a whispering touch up my neck, then back down to my shoulder. Her second hand joins in there, circling my bicep with both palms and sets of fingers. Keeping my eyes closed, I grin up at the ceiling and deliberately flex.

I hear her make a little *noise,* something involuntary and gutteral, and oh, fuck -

Fuck, it's pretty hot to be the object of desire that caused that noise.

"Show off," Adora murmurs, and I'm trying to figure out a clever comeback to that when I feel her breath hot against my shoulder

and then she's kissing, slow and wet and heated, down the muscle I was just flaunting. My words die on my lips, changed to hitched breath as Catra drapes a leg over one of mine and torturously rubs our thighs together without quite reaching anywhere *between* my legs.

"Feel nice?" Catra murmurs in my ear.

"Yeah," I confess, the word a sigh of pleasure. I feel Adora's mouth against my bicep shift briefly into a smile.

Catra's hand drifts up from my breast and instead settles in my hair, her fingers running gently through it and dragging my mind further into that cozy, fuzzy state of letting go. I'm comfortable but also, at the same time, very, very pent up. Each slow, steady breath in and out seems to align with the friction of Catra's thigh against mine, and as Adora's kisses trails lower and lower down my arm, to my elbow, to my forearm, I feel the steady pulse between my legs getting louder and louder.

As I'm starting to feel myself unclench and drift, Catra's other hand touches lightly at my chin, one careful clawtip gingerly pressing at my lower lip, and my mouth falls open in willing surrender.

Catra chuckles.

“You’re so turned on right now, aren’t you?” She asks, and I know she already knows the answer to that.

“Yeah,” I say breathily - there’s no point in pretending otherwise, with how my chest is heaving, and, well -

“Fuck, you’re wet,” Adora remarks, sounding surprised but smug. “Been waiting a while, huh?” Her fingers appear unexpectedly at my knee, drawing upwards along my inner thigh, and pull a strained whimper from me.

“I don’t - don’t mind,” I somehow manage to say, focused on keeping my eyes shut and trying not to tense up in my eagerness.

“You know, Adora,” Catra murmurs in my ear, “I’m always telling you how damn good you are with your mouth. I have to admit… the idea of you actually *knowing* how incredible it feels is pretty damn hot.”

I swallow hard, unsure of how to respond to this. I feel Adora’s fingertips whisper promisingly against my hip bone. I’m about to remind her she doesn’t *have* to, that she doesn’t owe me anything, but as I start forming those words I feel Catra twist over and put an arm on either side of my head and then she’s kissing me, kissing with such ferocity and love that thoughts, well -

Thoughts are gone, banished and evacuated and -

I'm just kissing, kissing Catra desperately with my left hand settled loosely on her hip while some other part of my brain tracks the way Adora has started moving, and I feel the mattress dip between my legs, and oh, if I wasn't already wet before I'm sure as fuck wet *now,* from the incredible *anticipation,* from the unbearable overwhelming thrill of it all - because this can't *really* be happening, can it?

I slide my hand from Catra's hip to her chest, unable to resist the temptation to get one of those perfect breasts in my palm and tease her a little as she sends me to dizzying heights of loose, giddy arousal with each hungry, adoring kiss. She moans into my mouth at the touch, and the sound makes me *throb,* and that makes me even more aware of the fact that Adora is kissing up the inside of my thigh, and fuck, *fuck,* this is -

"Mnyou," I gasp, in between kisses, unable to keep my eyes closed any longer, "You don't - don't have to."

Catra - looking, to my gratification, as out of breath as I feel - pulls away and settles over my chest, head tucked under my chin so that I have a clear line of sight to Adora.

"Do you not want me to?" Adora asks quite seriously, pausing her progress and meeting my eyes.

Of course I - oh fuck it's so weird to admit - of *course* I want her to, I'm horny and I'm curious and -

"I do," I say quickly, embarrassed, knowing I'm flushed for more than one reason. "I just - want to make sure you want to, too."

Adora grins up at me from between my thighs, and then that grin becomes a *smirk,* and she raises an eyebrow at me.

"You liked getting to make that fantasy of ours come true." I feel a hot twist of thrilling desire at my core as she smirks that damn cocky smirk up at me. "Aren't you curious? I know I want to know if I'm really as good as Catra says I am."

Yeah. *Yeah,* I'm fucking *curious.*

"Fuck," I groan, flopping my head back into the pillows again. "Okay. Yeah. Okay. Let's do this."

"For sure you want to?" Adora double-checks.

"Come on," I growl huskily, rocking my hips in her direction, "Show me what you've got."

That does it - I see the haze of arousal in her eyes, the glint of competitiveness.

Catra, draped across my chest, chuckles darkly and starts kissing her way back up my neck. I exhale a long, hard breath as Adora lowers her face again to resume trailing kisses up my thighs.

My whole body buzzes with sensation. I look down and my mind reels with how impossible the situation is, and -

And then her mouth is on me, heat and pressure wrapped blissfully around my clit, and *fuck* -

I gasp, and Catra takes that as her cue to bite down on my neck, and I shudder and keen at the onslaught of attention.

Catra's hand finds my breast again, grasping and toying with my nipple and layering on another set of sensations, and I swear again, out loud this time.

And then Adora -

Oh, fuck, *Adora.*

Catra is - Catra is definitely good with her mouth. But -

Fuck, is this - is this really what I'm like? So -

Earnest -

Enthusiastic -

I gasp and clutch at the sheets as Adora gets the tempo going *just right,* and then I feel her fingers start to press against me, and as this is happening Catra puts her mouth around the shell of my ear, biting gently, breathing hard, and -

F - fuck - I -

"Fuck," I stammer, my body roaring with pleasure as Adora's fingers push inside me and her tongue works its circles against my clit in just that perfect way, like she knows, like she *knows* exactly when it starts to feel perfect -

"This has to be the hottest thing I've ever seen in my life," Catra gasps against my ear. "Look at the way you're making yourself tremble. Feels good, doesn't it, princess? You feel how good you are at this? This is what you put me through all the time."

Her growling, smirking commentary is just fuel on the fire of this blazingly intense experience, and I don't - I don't have *words,* just noises, just breath - and -

And Adora starts to curl her fingers inside me and all my vision goes *white.*

"That's it, baby," Catra whispers, "You look so good like this. Fuck. I love watching you touch yourself but this is something *else."* Her sly smile out of the corner of my eye makes me feel like I'm in freefall, it turns me on so much to see when I'm already so - *fuck* - so close, and -

And then I stop being able to perceive what exactly Adora's doing because it's all just *incredible, incredible, incredible,* too good for words, too good to describe, too good to stand -

"Come on, baby," Catra says, running her fingers through my hair again and then - *fuck* - tugging, pulling my head back, explosing more of my neck. "Let go. Let it take you. You're safe. Let go."

And then Catra pulls my hair and bites my neck and Adora's *mouth* and *hands* and I'm coming, I'm coming, I'm *coming* -

My body seems to fill with light, blisteringly intense pleasure, golden and brilliant and ruthless.

I can feel Adora clinging to me just as relentlessly as I curl inwards and clench my thighs tight around her, not letting me stop, not letting my body squirm away, and -

Another peak hits me, blinding -

I'm shouting, I think, but if I am I know it can't possibly be words.

Adora pushes me up and over the height of ecstasy and I take as much as I can as she continues working her mouth against me even on the other side of it as I come back down. Panting, I gently push her away - too sensitive, now, to keep going - and only then does she stop.

I curl over and into Catra, who is there, right there, holding me tight as I gasp for breath, for meaning, for some hold on reality.

Ohhhh *fuck.*

My body thrums and twitches with aftershocks.

My mind is - blank? Whirling? Empty? Full?

Maybe there were never two Adoras at all. Maybe I just came so hard that I literally imagined everything up until this moment.

Just as I think this, I feel her - the other me, the other Adora - come up behind me in the bed and settle against my back. She

presses a damp kiss between my shoulder blades and then pulls the discarded blanket up and over the three of us.

"So? What's the verdict?" I hear Adora ask teasingly.

"Hm?" I murmur, dazed, wrapping my arms around Catra's waist and clutching her tightly to me, twining my legs around hers and trapping her in my hold.

"We as good at that as Catra says?"

As soon as it clicks as to what she's talking about, I laugh, startled, overwhelmed.

"Uhuh," I declare, releasing one arm on Catra so that I can twine my fingers through the hand I feel settling on my waist - Adora's hand. My hand. "Ye - yeah. We're fuckin' *good* at that."

"Dammit," Catra mutters, "Now you're gonna have even more of an ego."

"Price to pay for having a girlfriend who's that good with her tongue," Adora quips from the other side of me.

"Ugh, you're gonna be insufferable now, aren't you," Catra groans, very clearly wearing a smile, from her tone.

"Mhm," I confirm sleepily, kissing the crown of her head. "'Cause we're the best."

"Ugh," Catra huffs again, her smile even louder. "Guess I can't exactly argue with that."

I feel myself fading towards sleep, and allow it to happen.

Adora will watch over us.

If she needs me, she'll wake me up.

We'll protect Catra. From *anything.*

As I'm drifting off, I feel her kissing idly, affectionately, along the back of my shoulders and my neck. I smile, feeling the pleasant reassurance of the little touches lull me even deeper into relaxation.

I brush my fingertips along her forearm and down to the back of her hand, and I almost think I feel a ghostly echo of the sensation in my own arm.

I’m too tired to question it; I sleep.

The morning moonlight splashes across the bedspread, warming Adora’s face.

She feels rested, like she usually does on rare mornings like this one where she managed to actually sleep in without getting up at the crack of early moonrise for a jog or a sparring session or to read the latest Important Documents to come through.

Something is different about today though. It takes her a second to remember *why,* but -

She sits up suddenly, looking around.

She’s gone. She-Ra is gone.

Catra flicks an ear and stretches, but then rolls over and seems to settle back into sleep.

Adora's about to shake her awake and ask if she saw She-Ra leave when something makes her hesitate.

She thinks back on her memories of the night, and realizes that there's -

She remembers it all. From both sides.

She remembers looking at She-Ra in shock.

She remembers *being* She-Ra, looking at *Adora* in shock.

She remembers watching She-Ra, huge and buff and sweet and goofy and kind, laughingly race with her to be the first to get naked.

She remembers looking down at Adora, sprawled on her ass with her pants around her ankles.

All of it. She has the memories from all of it.

Quietly overwhelmed in the calm, gentle light of the morning, Adora touches her fingers to her lips and *remembers.*

She remembers what it felt like to look at herself and really, genuinely love the person she saw. To see every obvious gesture of thoughtfulness and consideration and think of it as something wonderful, not something weak.

To see herself exhausted and confused and stressed and instead of feeling pity or disdain, feel compassion and care and patience.

She still feels it, is the thing.

Her hand moves from her lips to her chest. She presses her balled fists hard against her sternum, like She-Ra is in there and if she presses hard enough, she'll feel all that love given in return.

And - well.

She *does.*

Because She-Ra hasn't vanished, hasn't disappeared.

She-Ra *is* her.

She-Ra was her all along.

Her hands soften, her fists loosen.

She cups her own face in one rough palm, and remembers loving this hand, loving this face.

When Catra finally wakes, she wakes to the sight of Adora standing naked in front of the mirror, hugging herself as she smiles through silent tears.

Adora can't explain it to Catra, not *exactly,* but she tries.

"So she's not… *gone,* gone," Catra says, after she manages to pull Adora back to the bed where Catra can hold her and wipe away each tear.

"No," Adora says, still smiling that confusing smile. "She's me. And I'm her. And I loved her, and she loved me, and - I don't. I really don't know how to explain it." She frowns, and then smiles, and then shakes her head in wonder. Then she crawls closer to Catra, and kisses her with infinite, shameless tenderness. Catra looks back at her in mild surprise as she pulls away from this sudden display. "Thank you," Adora whispers.

“What for?” Catra asks, a puzzled smile spreading across her face.

“For showing me that it was okay. For - for encouraging me.”

Catra keeps smiling, reaching out and brushing some hair back behind Adora’s ear.

“I don’t know if I deserve all that much credit. But I’m glad.” She leans in and kisses Adora, matches the soft, intimate energy of that first kiss. They keep their foreheads pressed together, as they often do, when the kiss ends.

“It was special,” Adora whispers reverently, glad to have someone like Catra to share this strange, wonderful revelation with. “Last night was special.”

“It was,” Catra agrees. “It definitely was.”

Without pulling away from Catra, Adora touches her own hand, running her thumb across the knuckles fondly. Warmth fills her chest, mirroring the warmth of the light pouring through their bedroom window.

She smiles.

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